A Theory of Economic Slack

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CHAPTER 21.

Slack around the world

As we saw in chapter 2, by its free-market nature, the United States might be the economy least hospitable to slack. Yet slack is ubiquitous in the US economy. It is therefore natural to expect that other countries present at least as much slack as the United States—which implies that the book's theory of slack might be fruitful there too.

In this chapter we review worldwide evidence on slack. We find that slack is prevalent all over the world, in developed and developing countries. We then discuss how the theory of slack might help us better understand business cycles and development in other countries.

21.1. Prevalence of slack in other countries

In this section we review evidence that slack is present in labor and product markets all around the world.

21.1.1. Labor market slack in other countries

Unemployment is a universal problem, found in labor markets all around the world. For instance, across 73 developed and developing countries, in the years 2000 to 2003, the unemployment rate averages 8.7%, with a minimum value of 1.4% and a maximum value of 30.7% (Feldmann 2009, table 2). This is why it is so important to study unemployment, include it in our models, and account for it in policymaking.

Unemployment is present throughout the developed world (Elsby, Hobijn, and Sahin 2013). The Beveridge curve is more or less visible in all these countries (Elsby, Michaels, and Ratner 2015). Unemployment is also prevalent in the developing world (O'Higgins 2003, figure 11). Although developing countries do not seem to have more unemployment than developed countries, they experience a much higher share of self-employment. And self-employment appears to be a mild form of unemployment, as workers choose self-employment primarily because they face unemployment in the formal sector. Hence, it is likely that there is even more labor market slack in the developing world.[1]

The psychological cost of unemployment has also been confirmed in other developed countries. Just like in the United States, unemployed workers in the United Kingdom suffer from low mental well-being (Clark and Oswald 1994; Blanchflower and Oswald 2004). And they are much more likely to be anxious and depressed and to suffer from low self-esteem—even compared to workers in low-pay jobs (Theodossiou 1998). A typical concern about studies linking unemployment to poor health is that they might not be able to distinguish between causality (unemployment causes poor health) and selection (people in poor health are more likely to become unemployed). But panel data, following workers over time, are able to identify the causal effect of unemployment on health. For instance, using a large, representative panel dataset of German workers, Winkelmann and Winkelmann (1998) find that unemployment reduces life satisfaction and that the nonpecuniary cost of unemployment is much larger than the pecuniary cost. Using the same panel dataset, Lucas et al. (2004) find that people do not get used to becoming unemployed: workers who have already lost jobs in the past react as badly to a new spell of unemployment as workers who are becoming unemployed for the first time.

Unemployment also seems to have extremely high psychosocial costs in the developing world. A field experiment by Hussam et al. (2022) in Bangladesh illustrates just how large the psychosocial cost of unemployment is. The experiment shows that paid employment raises psychosocial well-being substantially more than the same amount of cash alone. In fact, two-thirds of the workers who were employed in the experiment would be willing to forgo cash payments and continue working for free.

[1] Poschke (2025, figure 1) documents the prevalence of self-employment in the developing world. Robinson (1936) originally suggested that self-employment was a form of "disguised unemployment." Schoar (2010) argues that a substantial share of self-employed workers are "subsistence entrepreneurs," who are likely to come into self-employment from unemployment, to leave self-employment for better jobs whenever they can, and are primarily motivated by the need to support their family and lack of other options. Breza, Kaur, and Shamdasani (2021) confirm that in India, workers are pushed into self-employment when they cannot find jobs in the formal sector. Donovan, Lu, and Schoellman (2023) confirm this finding in a broad set of developing countries.

21.1.2. Product market slack in other countries

Slack is also present in product markets all over the world. Walker et al. (2024, figure 1) show that slack prevails in firms across the globe, and that rates of slack are higher in low-income countries. The slackish framework might therefore be useful not only in developed countries but also in developing countries.

A visible source of product market slack is wasted food. UN Environment Programme (2021) documents that food unsold by grocery stores and restaurants generates a significant amount of food waste across the globe. Brancoli (2021) provides a specific example: he explains why bread remains unsold at grocery stores in Sweden and documents how this generates food waste.

In the European Union, the European Commission (2025) measures slack in the product market through a large-scale firm survey. Just like the Institute for Supply Management in the United States, it asks firms the following question: "If the demand addressed to your firm expanded, could you increase your volume of activity with your present resources? Yes-No. If so, by how much?" Any firm with idle capacity will answer "yes" and say how much more they could sell (European Central Bank 2014). From the measured capacity utilization rate, we can create a rate of idleness, which is just 1 – utilization rate. In the manufacturing sector, between 1985:Q1 and 2024:Q4, the idleness rate averages 19.3%, and it fluctuates between 15.4% and 32.7%.[2] In the service sector, between 2011:Q3 and 2024:Q4, the idleness rate averages 10.7%, and it fluctuates between 8.7% and 14.2%. So just like in the United States, product markets display substantial slack in Europe (figure 21.1).

Product market slack is not limited to Europe, of course. Walker et al. (2024, table 1) report widespread product market slack across Kenya, in both rural and urban environments. For non-agricultural enterprises across thousands of homesteads, villages, rural markets, and urban markets surveyed between 2019 and 2024, the idleness rate is 39%—that is, 39% of total capacity is not utilized. They also observe that the idleness rate of labor is 53%—that is, 53% of workers' time is not spent on productive activity. The idleness rate of labor is much higher in rural environments: 61% in homesteads and 52% in villages, against only 15% in urban markets. Another striking finding from the Kenyan surveys is that 37% of firms would incur zero additional costs to expand their output by 10%. And the substantial amount of slack observed in Kenya seem to exist in other African countries too. In a survey of more than a thousand manufacturing firms in Uganda, Bassi et al. (2025, table A1) find that the idleness rate of labor is 26%. They also report that workers spend 11% of their time simply waiting for customers.

Another element suggesting that product market slack is prevalent globally is that sellers strive to form long-term relationships with buyers in all countries. For example,

[2]The question asked to manufacturing firms is slightly different from the question above, which is asked to service firms, but in practice it seems that firms answer this question (European Central Bank 2007).

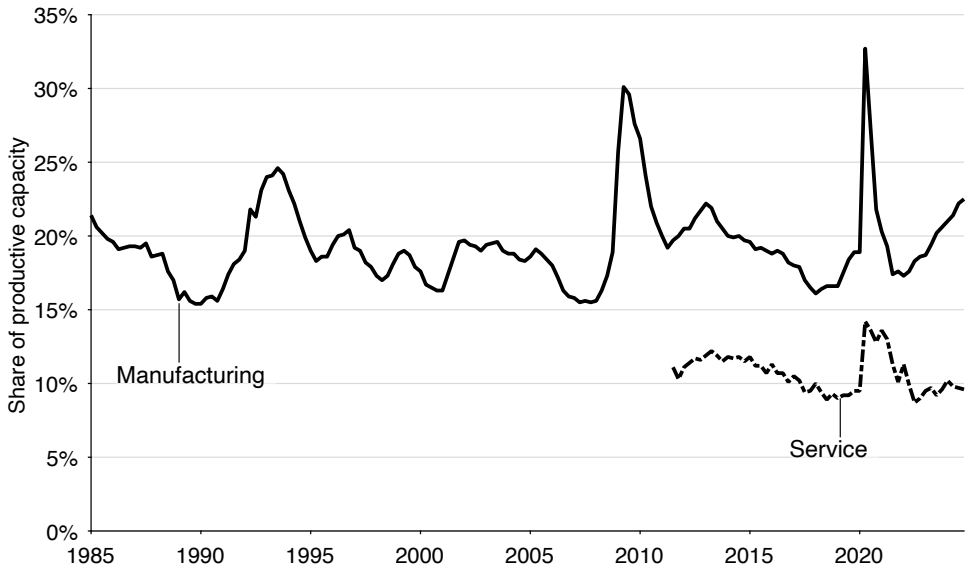


FIGURE 21.1. Idle capacity in the European Union, 1985–2024

The idleness rates are quarterly series constructed from the capacity utilization rates in the manufacturing and service sectors measured by European Commission (2025) from business surveys. For the service sector, the idleness rate is only available after 2011:Q3.

70% of firms in the Euro area have long-term relationships with their customers (Fabiani et al. 2006, table B3). Firms in developing countries also appear to rely heavily on long-term relationships to operate. Macchiavello (2022, p. 340) reviews a wide range of evidence and concludes that in developing countries:

> Many—and perhaps most—transactions between firms occur in long-term relationships rather than in spot markets, as typically theorized in economic models.

Long-term customer relationships are governed by implicit contracts that alleviate matching problems, as I found in a survey of French bakers in the summer of 2007.[3] First, customer relationships alleviate the uncertainty associated with random demand. A baker told me that demand is difficult to predict and that having a large clientele of loyal customers who make it a habit to purchase bread in the shop was therefore important. In fact, "good" customers are expected to come every day to the bakery. Customer relationships also alleviate the uncertainty associated with random supply. Being a customer means having the assurance that your usual bread will be available, even on days when supply runs low. Of course, this is possible because bakers know exactly what customers order every day through their long association. A baker told me that it would be "unacceptable"

[3]The survey is described in Eyster, Madarasz, and Michaillat (2021).

to run out of bread for a customer, and that customers would probably "leave the bakery" if that happened.

21.1.3. International trade

Domestic product markets around the world appear slackish, in that it takes time to sell goods and services, it takes effort to buy them, and buyers and sellers alleviate these difficulties by forming long-term customer relationships. International product markets appear at least as slackish: the geographical, cultural, and legal distance makes it difficult to trade with buyers or sellers in other countries—even more so in other continents. It is because of these difficulties that sellers and buyers are keen to form long-lasting cross-country relationships (Egan and Mody 1992, table 3).

21.1.4. Price and wage rigidities in other countries

The price and wage rigidity used in the book's theory also appear in other countries, which makes a framework with rigid price and wage norms particularly applicable. Indeed, across the globe, prices and wages do not appear to be fully responsive to shocks. Administrative data and household surveys across 16 Western countries show that wages are fairly rigid (Dickens et al. 2007). Wage rigidity is also prevalent in developing countries (Kaur 2019). Large-scale firm surveys show that prices are quite rigid throughout the Euro area (Fabiani et al. 2006). Given such rigidities, we expect fluctuations in slack to be substantial—because adjustments in slack are required to equilibrate supply and demand when prices are rigid.

We argued that price and wage rigidities might be caused by fairness concerns, and we provided evidence from the United States. But there is substantial evidence that people in other countries also care about fairness: Frey and Pommerehne (1993) provides evidence from Switzerland and Germany, Gielissen, Dutilh, and Graafland (2008) from the Netherlands, and Boycko and Shiller (2016) from Russia. Firms across the globe also identify fairness as a major concern in price setting. Researchers have surveyed more than 12,000 firms across developed economies about their pricing practices; among the theories that the managers deem most important in explaining price rigidity, some version of "being fair to customers" invariably appears (Eyster, Madarasz, and Michaillat 2021, tables 1 and 2).

More generally, we assumed that social norms determine prices and wages in slackish markets. This assumption is consistent with Lewis (1954, p. 189)'s observation that in the developing world, many workers were available to work at a wage determined by a social norm: "a conventional view of the minimum required for subsistence." Ranis (2004, pp. 717–718) explains that such a wage is "an exogenous unskilled agricultural real

wage," instead of a real wage "determined endogenously by the interaction of demand and supply," and he argues that such a wage is supported by historical and anthropological evidence.

In general, social norms determine how people think they should behave and others should behave (Akerlof and Kranton 2010, chapter 2). Hence, workers will refuse to work for an employer who violates the norm—who pays a wage that is too low—and they will be willing to punish other workers who accept work at a norm-violating wage. Breza, Kaur, and Krishnaswamy (2025) find that all of this occurs in Indian labor markets, even when unemployment is high: Indian workers not only refuse to work at below-normal wages, but they are willing to pay to punish workers who accept such abnormally low wages.

21.2. Applying the theory of slack to other countries

In this book we built the theory of slack based on US evidence, calibrated the models to the US economy, and applied the theory to US policies. But, as unemployment and slack more generally exist everywhere, this book's theory should be helpful in other countries too: to understand how markets operate, how business cycles affect the economy, and how policies can be used to improve market outcomes.

21.2.1. Labor market policies

The slackish labor market model developed in this book has already been helpful to understand the effects of various labor market policies in several European countries: for example, in France (Crepon et al. 2013), in Austria (Lalive, Landais, and Zweimuller 2015), and in Sweden (Cheung et al. 2025). It might be helpful to study other policies in comparable labor markets.

The model might also be helpful to understand developing economies and design appropriate policies to combat poverty and foster development, and thus to provide more fulfilling lives to workers everywhere. Indeed, although developing countries see large flows of workers in the labor market (Donovan, Lu, and Schoellman 2023), job rationing in the formal sector is prevalent (Breza, Kaur, and Shamdasani 2021). The model implies for instance that policies that stimulate labor demand, such as public employment, might reduce unemployment and poverty effectively.[4] Public employment might be especially potent in slack labor markets, when it crowds out private employment less. The theory provides support for India's public work program, the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act, and suggests that the program might be especially effective in slack labor markets, just as Breza, Kaur, and Shamdasani (2021, section 8) find.

[4] A further advantage of public employment programs is that they allow policy to reach the rural poor (Ravallion 1991).

21.2.2. Self-employed economies

In chapter 13, we developed the simplest possible slackish model of an aggregate economy. In that model, all workers are self-employed and sell their production directly to other people. This is not very realistic to describe the modern US economy or other developed economies, where most production is mediated by firms. But it might be useful to describe developing economies because there a large share of the labor force is indeed self-employed. As Porta and Shleifer (2014, figure 4) show, the share of workers in the labor force who are self-employed decreases sharply with GDP per capita; the share is close to 100% in the world's poorest countries. The model of chapter 13 might be particularly well adapted to describe the economy of such countries, and to explain why slack is so prevalent there.

21.2.3. Aggregate shocks

In the book we find that fluctuations in unemployment in the United States are driven by labor demand shocks. It would be interesting to assess if this conclusion holds in other countries. Because we reached that conclusion from Okun's law, a first step would be to ascertain whether Okun's law holds in other countries. Ball, Leigh, and Loungani (2017) show that it holds in 20 developed economies, which suggests that labor demand shocks also play a central role there. Ball et al. (2019) extend these results and show that Okun's law holds in many developing economies as well. The slackish business cycle model might therefore be useful in all these economies, as it features labor demand shocks that are nonneutral and produce meaningful unemployment fluctuations that respect Okun's law.

We went one step further and found that these labor demand shocks in fact arise from underlying aggregate demand shocks, not technology shocks. It would be good to know if this conclusion holds in other countries as well. We reached the conclusion by producing product Okun curves, which link short-run fluctuations in output and product market slack. It would be interesting to produce similar plots in other countries. The challenge would be to obtain good measures of product market slack there.

Finally, because agriculture is such an important component of developing economies, seasons generate fluctuations in labor demand and thus slack.[5] It might be fruitful to adapt the slackish model to agricultural economies with seasonal cycles, to understand better the fluctuations in slack that seasons produce and to design better policies to alleviate seasonal poverty.

[5] See for instance (Boserup 1965) and Devereux, Vaitla, and Swan (2008) for general discussions and evidence. See Paxson (1993) for evidence from Thailand and Bryan, Chowdhury, and Mobarak (2014) for evidence from Bangladesh.

21.2.4. Labor and total factor productivity

A task related to understanding the sources of slack fluctuations is to use slack data to obtain better measures of labor productivity and total factor productivity, purified from fluctuations in slack. Although labor and total factor productivity might not be an important driver of business cycles, productivity is of course a primary driver of economic growth, so measuring it well is important to understand economic development. As we discussed, measuring productivity accurately requires to measure slack accurately and to properly separate fluctuations in slack from fluctuations in productivity—as both enter fluctuations in measured productivity.

Another question related to labor productivity in the developing world stems from the work of Lewis (1954), who postulated that these economies were divided between a productive capitalist sector and a less-productive noncapitalist sector—including agriculture, domestic and other services, handicrafts, local retail, and so on. Lewis argued that moving a chunk of the labor force from the noncapitalist to the capitalist sector would boost the country's productivity without affecting much noncapitalist production—especially food production. This view has been challenged by modern development economists who observe that people do earn an income in the noncapitalist sector. Gollin (2014, pp. 79–80) proposed that the resolution between the two views might come from the market structure in developing countries:

> When one additional individual joins the queue of roadside sellers of popcorn or flyswatters in Kampala or Chittagong, the marginal product of that individual's labor may be positive for that individual and his or her family; but whether there is a positive social value is unclear. Arguably, this individual is simply taking business from other sellers, creating little or no additional social value.

The theory of slack immediately resolves this conundrum: as the noncapitalist market is typically very slack, a negative supply shock such as a reduction in the noncapitalist labor force would have a very small effect on output, just as Lewis (1954) argued. However, of course, workers do earn an income on the noncapitalist market, just as modern development economists observed. The resolution is that when workers move out of the market, market tightness goes up, so it becomes easier for remaining workers to sell their goods and services. Therefore, as Gollin (2014) hypothesized, output does not drop as much as what the micro evidence might have suggested, because the micro effects are counteracted by the response of tightness, which increases.

21.2.5. FERU and unemployment gap

As the slackish framework developed in the book is likely to be applicable in other countries, the policy tools introduced in the book should also be applicable beyond the United States. Many countries have a full-employment mandate, but no clear full-employment target. Computing the FERU in these countries would be helpful to guide policymakers towards full employment.

Unemployment rate, vacancy rate, and labor market tightness can be computed in other countries in which data on the number of job seekers, number of job vacancies, and number of labor force participants are available. From this the FERU formula $u^* = \sqrt{uv}$ can be applied, and from it the unemployment gap $u - u^*$ can be computed. For instance, Gokten, Heimberger, and Lichtenberger (2024) apply the formula to Germany, Sweden, Austria, Finland, and the United Kingdom, and analyze the evolution of the unemployment gap in these countries since the 1970s. Liargovas et al. (2025) apply the formula and compute the unemployment gap in Greece, 2009–2024. Moving forward, the real-time unemployment gaps could be used to adjust monetary and fiscal policy in response to shocks in these countries, as described in the book.

However, the FERU formula does require assumptions on the cost of unemployment, the cost of recruiting, and the shape of the Beveridge curve. In countries in which these statistics take different values than in the United States, the FERU must be computed from a more general formula. The shape of the Beveridge curve is particularly likely to differ across countries (Gaddnas and Keranen 2023, table 1). In that case, it is necessary to use the generalized formula for the efficient labor market tightness and adjust the calibration of the parameters. Gaddnas and Keranen (2023) take a step in that direction and compute the FERU in Finland, Sweden, Germany, and the Netherlands using country-specific Beveridge elasticities. Germain (2024) compute the FERU in Belgium's three regions—Brussels, Flanders, and Wallonia—using region-specific Beveridge elasticities.

21.2.6. Phillips curve

In the book we build a slackish Phillips curve that links slack to inflation. There is good evidence in favor of the slackish Phillips curve in the United States, and it would be fascinating to see whether the slackish Phillips curve holds in other countries too: Do we see that slack is a superior indicator of inflationary pressures? And do we see that when the economy is at full employment, inflation is on target? Benigno and Eggertsson (2024) have started to explore these questions. They find similar patterns in other countries, but more research to confirm and expand these findings would be valuable. A key empirical challenge here again is to find measures of slack that are of good quality and that cover a sufficiently long period.

One piece of evidence suggests that the slackish Phillips curve might describe well the behavior of inflation in the developing world. Egger et al. (2022) find that a large fiscal stimulus in Kenya led to a sizeable increase in consumption but a minimal change in price inflation. At the same time, Walker et al. (2024) showed that the Kenyan economy is exceedingly slack. This is consistent with the property of the slackish Phillips curve, which we found to be almost flat in slack economies; hence, even with endogenous inflation, we would expect inflation to increase very little in response to the fiscal stimulus.

21.2.7. Slack dependence of policy multipliers

The slackish model is sharply state dependent. This implies that the effectiveness of policies varies sharply with the state of the economy. For example, in the slackish labor market model, we saw that when the labor market is slacker, public employment reduces unemployment more effectively, in-migration raises unemployment more sharply, and unemployment insurance—although it continues to reduce job-search effort—raises unemployment less. In the slackish business cycle model, when the economy is slacker, fiscal and monetary policy reduce unemployment more effectively.

It would be interesting to investigate these predictions systematically in other countries. This investigation would help design better policies, because it would indicate when certain policies are particularly effective. The investigation would also be useful to evaluate the theory of slack.

Several papers offer promising starting evidence, as they found slack-dependent policy multipliers abroad. For instance, Auerbach and Gorodnichenko (2013) estimate state-dependent fiscal multipliers in numerous OECD countries; Holden and Sparrman (2016) estimate state-dependent public-spending multipliers in 20 OECD countries; and Kopiec and Walerych (2026) estimate a slack-dependent monetary multiplier in Poland. These papers find that public spending and monetary policy reduce the unemployment rate more effectively when the economy is slack than when it is tight, as the theory of slack would predict. And in Brazil Gerard, Naritomi, and Silva (2026, table B3) find that cash transfers increase formal employment by stimulating local demand, and that they are much more effective in municipalities with above-average unemployment rate.

21.2.8. Recession detection

The Michez+ recession indicator can also be computed for any country in which unemployment and vacancy data are available, but the recession threshold of 0.19pp will need to be recalibrated. In other countries, the recession indicator takes different values, and recessions occur at different times, so the threshold must be recomputed to detect recessions as early and accurately as possible. It might also be possible to optimize how the

unemployment and vacancy data are smoothed and combined to best detect recessions in other countries, using the method described in Michaillat (2025). For instance, Sikand and Zhang (2026) show that the approach performs well in Japan.

21.2.9. Out-of-equilibrium dynamics

When we considered dynamic markets, where trading relationships are formed and destroyed over time, we concentrated on the equilibrium—where market flows are balanced so slack is constant. In the US labor market, flows are large, so out-of-equilibrium dynamics are fast and unlikely to matter much. But such dynamics may matter more on other US markets, or in other countries. For instance, labor market flows are much smaller in continental Europe (Elsby, Hobijn, and Sahin 2013, table 4). So there it would be important to study and incorporate out-of-equilibrium market dynamics.

21.3. Collecting better evidence on slack

Because slack is not a core concept in macroeconomic research, statistical agencies have not systematically collected data on it—beyond unemployment. Hence, many measures of slack reported in this book—for the United States and other countries—are imperfect in some ways. Collecting better slack data would help improve the design of slack-centered economic models and the conduct of slack-based economic policies. To conclude the chapter, this section discusses which type of data and evidence would be especially valuable.

The most important form of slack is unemployment, so the most important statistic is the number of unemployed workers at any point in time. Developed countries now collect such data, but many developing countries still do not. It seems critical to start measuring unemployment in these countries to track and stabilize business cycle fluctuations.

One challenge is that many workers are self-employed in the developing world, and workers who are self-employed are neither as idle as unemployed workers nor as occupied as formal workers, so they only partially contribute to slack in the economy. To complicate matters, Maloney (2004, p. 1161) reports that in Latin America about 30% of the self-employed are in the occupation involuntarily, while 70% choose to be self-employed voluntarily, enjoying the flexibility and independence from self-employment. Presumably, the involuntarily self-employed could be more productive and work longer hours if they were employed by firms, so they contribute more significantly to aggregate slack. The voluntarily self-employed may be producing and earning as much as they can in their occupation, and they might not contribute to aggregate slack at all. Keeping track of slack among the self-employed might require measuring unemployed hours. The unemployment rate among the self-employed would be the share of the time that they are

idle.

To assess the tightness of foreign labor markets, it would be key to collect monthly data on job vacancies. To assess the full-employment rate of unemployment, as well as the unemployment gap, it would be important to measure the amount of labor devoted to recruiting in these labor markets. At the minimum, vacancies can be translated into recruiters by assuming some constant number of recruiters per vacancy; but it would be even better to have direct, monthly measures of the number of recruiters.

Of course, in addition to data on slack in the labor market, it would be extremely instructive to measure slack in the product market systematically. This would require measuring the slack rate in firms, small and large, as the European Commission does in the European Union. These surveys ask firms how much more they could produce, given their current capital stock and workforce and organization, if only they had more demand for their product. In the slackish framework, this is the ideal information to compute the slack rate in the product market.

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